

2026 SEASON · DRAFT GUIDE

Everything you need before you're **on the clock**

Ten sections: the 2025 repricing, a strategy, five position files, a slot-by-slot plan and three mock drafts.

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Rankings are consensus-leaning composites, not any single board. ADP and injury status are perishable — this is the picture as of 25 July 2026. Re-check anything involving a knee before you draft.

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LAST SEASON

RESULT	WHY IT MATTERS NOW
Seahawks won Super Bowl LX, 29–13	Kenneth Walker III took MVP, then left for Kansas City.
Jaxon Smith-Njigba, OPOY	Top-five receiver, no target competition.
Christian McCaffrey, overall FF1	403 touches. Every risk model flinches.
Josh Allen, 374.6 pts (QB1)	Buffalo then traded for D.J. Moore.

Three facts that shape the board

- **RB is expensive again.** A dozen real workhorses, ADP pushed up.
- **Thin rookie class.** No cheap injury replacements in August.
- **Two stars are injury bets.** Mahomes (ACL/LCL), Nabers (second procedure).

SIX RULES

- **Draft tiers, not ranks.** Move when a tier is about to empty.
- **Hero RB is the default.** One anchor early, receivers in the middle, backfields again from Round 6.
- **Zero RB only if the room forces it.** Thin rookie class means no waiver bailout.
- **Tight end: Round 2 or Round 11.** Nothing in between.
- **Never pay for a quarterback.** Two late arms, stream the matchup.
- **D and K with your last two picks.** Every year.

PHASE PLAN

PHASE PLAN

ROUNDS	DO	AVOID
1–2	Highest-certainty volume. Elite TE is fine here.	Chasing last year's points.
3–5	Receivers with target certainty. One injury discount, max.	Committee backs sold as starters.
6–9	Vacated target trees and standalone backfields.	Handcuffing your own starter.
10–13	Two QBs, second TE, useful handcuffs.	A third quarterback.
14+	Pure upside only.	Bye-week filler. It's free in September.

RB Running back

Expensive, thin past the top twelve. Two names in Tier 1.

BOARD

Tier 1 THE 1.01	Jahmyr GibbsDET Bijan RobinsonATL
Tier 2 ROUND 1	Christian McCaffreySF Ashton JeantyLV James CookBUF Jonathan TaylorIND
Tier 3 ROUNDS 2–3	Chase BrownCIN Josh JacobsGB Breece Hall– De’Von AchaneMIA Bucky IrvingTB Jeremiyah LoveARI TreVeyon HendersonNE
Chase Brown is the price break: RB10–13 in Round 3, 19.1 PPG over the last 10 games of 2025.	
Tier 4 ROUNDS 4–6	Bhayshul TutenJAX Cam SkatteboNYG Jadarian PriceSEA Kenneth Walker IIIKC Derrick HenryBAL Omarion HamptonLAC
The leverage tier. Buy here if you skipped Round 1.	
Tier 5 ROUNDS 7–11	Kenneth GainwellTB Trey BensonARI Rachaad White– Chris RodriguezJAX Jonathon BrooksCAR Zach CharbonnetSEA

MOVES

Kenneth Walker III SEA → KC	Value now rides on Mahomes' knee .
Travis Etienne Jr. JAX → NO · 4yr/\$52M	Jacksonville's backfield is Bhayshul Tuten's .
Kenneth Gainwell PIT → TB	1B to Bucky Irving, off 1,023 scrimmage yards.
Zach Charbonnet SEA · PUP, 22 July	Playoff ACL tear, no timeline. Opens the door for Jadarian Price .

NAMES

RB

Jahmyr Gibbs

DET

1.01

› 364.5 pts/season, last two years

› Montgomery gone — career-high workload

› Easiest RB schedule in the league

RB

Bijan Robinson

ATL

1.02

› Zero games missed, career

› RB3 then RB2

› The floor pick

RB

Chase Brown

CIN

RD 3

› 23.7 PPG in the fantasy playoffs

› 18.2 PPG minus 3 Browning starts — RB6 pace

› Priced as a low-end RB1

ROOKIES

2026 CLASS • RUNNING BACKS

PLAYER	PICK	READ
Jeremiyah Love ARI	Rd 1	Highest-drafted back since Barkley. Shares with Conner and Benson. Most likely rookie to finish top-15.
Jadarian Price SEA	32	Walker gone, Charbonnet on PUP. Clear path to lead back in a run-heavy offense.

GEMS

LATE-ROUND BACKS

PLAYER	COST	MECHANISM
Bhayshul Tuten JAX	~58	Already true. Lead back, priced RB25.
Kenneth Gainwell TB	~103	Already true. 73 catches, and Tampa feeds its backs.
Jadarian Price SEA	Rd 5–6	Needs to win camp, not an injury.
Jonathon Brooks CAR	Rd 10	Talent was never the question. Availability was.
Jordan James SF	Rd 14+	Handcuffed to 403 touches.
Keaton Mitchell BAL	Rd 14+	Henry's workload is the domino.

BOARD

Tier 1 ROUND 1	Ja'Marr ChaseCIN	Puka NacuaLAR	Jaxon Smith-NjigbaSEA	Amon-Ra St. BrownDET
Tier 2 ROUNDS 1–2	CeeDee LambDAL	Justin JeffersonMIN	A.J. BrownNE	Nico CollinsHOU
Tier 3 ROUNDS 2–4	DeVonta SmithPHI	Emeka EgbukaTB	George PickensDAL	Rashee RiceKC
	Malik NabersNYG	Rome OdunzeCHI		
Smith and Egbuka are the clean bets. Rice and Nabers are the discounts — own at most one.				
Tier 4 ROUNDS 5–8	Jaylen WaddleDEN	Josh DownsIND	Luther Burden IIICHI	D.J. MooreBUF
	Mike EvansSF	Courtland SuttonDEN	Carnell TateTEN	
Every name here inherited targets this offseason. Most profitable stretch of the draft.				
Tier 5 ROUNDS 9+	Brian Thomas Jr.JAX	Parker WashingtonJAX	Jordyn TysonNO	KC ConcepcionCLE
	Ryan FlourneyDAL	Jalen NailorMIN	Isaac TeSlaaDET	

MOVES

A.J. Brown PHI → NE	Reunites with Vrabel. DeVonta Smith inherits Philadelphia.
D.J. Moore CHI → BUF	Chicago condenses to Odunze, Burden, Loveland.
Jaylen Waddle MIA → DEN · 1st + 3rd	29th in neutral pass rate to 4th. Sutton still caps him.
Mike Evans TB → SF · 3yr/\$60.4M	Emeka Egbuka is now Tampa's unambiguous No. 1.
Michael Pittman Jr. IND → PIT · 3yr/\$59M	Josh Downs collects the targets.

NAMES

WR

DeVonta Smith

PHI

RD 2–3

> A.J. Brown gone — no target competition

> Alpha role for the first time

> Priced WR2, projects WR1

WR

Emeka Egbuka

TB

RD 3

> WR3 in PPG across Weeks 1–5 as a rookie

> 22.1% target share, 89 yds/game

> Inherits Evans' red-zone looks

WR

Luther Burden III

CHI

RD 6–7

> 2.3 yds/route run — led the Bears

> Did it on a sub-50% route rate

> Moore's trade unlocked the snaps

WR

Malik Nabers

NYG

RD 3–5

> Second procedure — scar tissue

> Avoided PUP, may miss 4–5 games

> Fine in Round 5. Not in Round 3.

ROOKIES

2026 CLASS • WIDE RECEIVERS

PLAYER	PICK	READ
Carnell Tate TEN	4	Consensus WR1 of the class. Heavy target share with Ward and Daboll. Projected 56/773/4.
Jordyn Tyson NO	8	CBS projects him the class's top producer: 61/869/4.
KC Concepcion CLE	24	Late-round dart with first-round capital.
Omar Cooper Jr. NYJ	30	Flex upside if the Jets' passing game sorts out.
Makai Lemon PHI	Rd 1	Dynasty-first, but Philadelphia has a vacancy.

GEMS

LATE-ROUND RECEIVERS

PLAYER	COST	MECHANISM
Luther Burden III CHI	Rd 6–7	Already true. Elite efficiency, snaps now unlocked.
Josh Downs IND	Rd 6–8	Already true. Needs Daniel Jones upright.
Ryan Flourney DAL	Rd 14+	WR3 behind Lamb and Pickens in a pass-heavy offense.
Jalen Nailor MIN	Rd 14+	One Jefferson absence from a flex.
Isaac TeSlaa DET	Rd 15+	Needs a route-share bump, not a leap.

TE Tight end

Round 2 or Round 11. The middle is the worst value on the board.

BOARD

Tier 1 ROUND 2	Brock BowersLV Trey McBrideARI Five to six points a week over replacement. Why Zero RB pairs with an elite TE.
Tier 2 ROUNDS 4–6	Colston LovelandCHI Tyler WarrenIND Tucker KraftGB Sam LaPortaDET The trap tier. Loveland is the one exception.
Tier 3 ROUNDS 7–10	Kyle PittsATL Harold Fannin Jr.CLE George KittleSF Travis KelceKC Jake FergusonDAL Isaiah LikelyBAL
Tier 4 ROUND 11+	Gunnar HelmTEN Chig OkonkwoWAS Brenton StrangeJAX T.J. HockensonMIN Hunter HenryNE Juwan JohnsonNO Cade OttonTB Take two, start the better matchup.

MOVES

Chig Okonkwo TEN → WAS	Hands the Titans job to Gunnar Helm .
Klint Kubiak SEA → LV · coaching	Main reason Bowers tops most boards.
D.J. Moore CHI → BUF	Gives Loveland the clearest mid-round volume path.

NAMES

TE Brock BowersLV RD 2 > 150+ targets last season > Chasing McBride's record 126 catches > Rookie QB is the one risk	TE Trey McBrideARI RD 2 > Reigning fantasy TE1 > 126 catches — position record > Arizona added a first-round back
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TE

Gunnar Helm TEN

RD 12+

> Okonkwo left — job is his

> Ward and Daboll running the offense

> Best single late-round TE bet

ROOKIES

None worth a redraft pick. Nobody's job got taken — part of why Tier 4 is so deep.

GEMS

DOUBLE-DIGIT-ROUND TIGHT ENDS

PLAYER	COST	MECHANISM
Gunnar Helm TEN	Rd 12+	Already true. Okonkwo left; Helm starts.
Chig Okonkwo WAS	Rd 13+	Clean role in an offense that feeds the position.
Brenton Strange JAX	Rd 13+	The stable target in an unstable receiver room.
T.J. Hockenson MIN	Rd 11+	Established role, depressed price.
Cade Otton TB	Rd 13+	Evans gone, Egbuka drawing coverage.

BOARD

Tier 1 IF YOU MUST PAY	Josh Allen BUF	Joe Burrow CIN	Drake Maye NE
Tier 2 BUY HERE	Lamar Jackson BAL	Jayden Daniels WAS	
Both drafted below what a healthy version is worth.			
Tier 3 INTERCHANGEABLE	Jaxson Dart NYG	Brock Purdy SF	Jalen Hurts PHI
	Matthew Stafford LAR	Dak Prescott DAL	Caleb Williams CHI
			Trevor Lawrence JAX
Mahomes belongs here, not higher. Low-end QB1 is the right price for a knee this fresh.			
Tier 4 WHERE TO SHOP	Bo Nix DEN	Tyler Shough NO	Cam Ward TEN
	Fernando Mendoza LV	Jacoby Brissett -	Malik Willis MIA

MOVES

Patrick Mahomes KC · ACL + LCL, Week 15	Cleared to practice, targeting Week 1. Was QB4 at 21.2 PPG before it.
D.J. Moore CHI → BUF	Buffalo gave the position's top scorer a real WR1.
Jaylen Waddle MIA → DEN	Denver spent a 1st to get Bo Nix a No. 1.
Fernando Mendoza Indiana → LV · No. 1	Matters more for Bowers than for your lineup.

ROOKIES

2026 CLASS · QUARTERBACKS

PLAYER	PICK	READ
Fernando Mendoza LV	1	Heisman winner, first overall. QB2 value in the right matchups. Matters more for Bowers.
Ty Simpson -	Rd 1	Dynasty stash only. Leave him on the board in redraft.

LATE-ROUND QUARTERBACKS

PLAYER	COST	MECHANISM
Bo Nix DEN	QB15	Two straight QB7 finishes, drafted QB15. Plus Waddle. Cleanest gap on the board.
Jaxson Dart NYG	Rd 9–11	8th-most PPG at the position from Week 4 on.
Tyler Shough NO	Rd 13+	QB12 in PPG across nine rookie starts. Now has Tyson.
Malik Willis MIA	11.11	Rushing ceiling in any week he starts.

DEF Defense

Your second-to-last pick. Four are worth owning; the rest you rent.

BOARD

Tier 1 WORTH A PICK	Rams LAR	Seahawks SEA	Broncos DEN	Eagles PHI
SportsLine puts four in Tier 1; PFF's top tier runs six. Philadelphia is the asterisk — DST7 in back-to-back seasons, but no team faces a harder defensive schedule in 2026.				
Tier 2 DRAFT OR STREAM	Ravens BAL	Texans HOU	Steelers PIT	Lions DET
Fine to roster, better to rotate. Baltimore and Detroit both draw soft openings.				
Tier 3 MATCHUP ONLY	Chargers LAC			
Drafted for a schedule, not a unit. Check Week 1 lines the morning of your draft — the rest of this tier is decided by who they open against.				

MOVES

Myles Garrett CLE → LAR	Last year's sack record-breaker joins a unit already 4th in pressure rate (26%). The single biggest reason the Rams top most boards.
Trent McDuffie · Jaylen Watson → LAR	Secondary rebuilt around the pass rush. Los Angeles led the NFL in dropped interceptions (10) — those become points now.
Jesse Minter → BAL · head coach	A healthier Ravens defense and the second-easiest schedule through six weeks.

STREAMERS

RENT, DON'T BUY

DEFENSE	WINDOW	WHY
Chargers LAC	Weeks 1–2	Arizona then Las Vegas — the best opening draw of any defense. Start with confidence, then move on.
Ravens BAL	Weeks 1–6	Favoured in all six, and only Dallas rates as an above-average offense. Draft last and forget the position for a month.
Lions DET	Weeks 1–5	Easiest schedule in the league over that stretch, plus positive injury regression due. The last-pick sleeper.
Seahawks SEA	All season	Highest-scoring D/ST of 2025 on the fewest points allowed (17.2). Top-five in back-to-back years under Mike Macdonald — the one you don't rotate.

08 Draft plan

RB or WR at pick 1? Answered for all twelve seats.

THE RULE

Two Tier-1 backs. Four Tier-1 receivers. That asymmetry decides it:

Picks 1–2 — open RB. Gibbs or Bijan will be there.

Picks 3–6 — open WR. Both Tier-1 backs are gone; a back here means reaching down a tier while a Tier-1 receiver sits there.

Picks 7–12 — open RB. Tier-1 receivers gone too, and the RB cliff is steeper.

One principle: **never reach across a tier break to fill a position.**

BY SLOT

1 1.01 · 2.12 · 3.01 Gibbs. Then take one back and one receiver at the turn. RB	2 1.02 · 2.11 · 3.02 Whichever of Gibbs or Bijan is left. Same turn logic. RB	3 1.03 · 2.10 · 3.03 Chase. Don't talk yourself into McCaffrey's 403 touches. WR
4 1.04 · 2.09 · 3.04 Nacua or Smith-Njigba. Then a back at 2.09, hard. WR	5 1.05 · 2.08 · 3.05 Last Tier-1 receiver. If they're gone, pivot to Jeanty. WR	6 1.06 · 2.07 · 3.06 St. Brown usually lasts. Cleanest seat for Hero RB. WR
7 1.07 · 2.06 · 3.07 The flip point. Jeanty, Cook or Taylor. RB	8 1.08 · 2.05 · 3.08 Last Tier-2 back. An elite TE at 2.05 is live here. RB	9 1.09 · 2.04 · 3.09 Jefferson or Lamb there? Take the receiver. Gone? Take the back. EITHER
10 1.10 · 2.03 · 3.10 Best available, then fill the gap at 2.03. EITHER	11 1.11 · 2.02 · 3.11 Take the tier that's emptying faster. Elite TE is live at 2.02. EITHER	12 1.12 · 2.01 · 3.12 Best turn on the board. Take a Tier-2 back and a Tier-2 receiver. EITHER

PIVOTS

- **Four backs go in the first six picks.** Take receivers, buy the Round 4–6 leverage tier late. This is when Zero RB switches on.
- **Bowers or McBride at your Round 2 pick.** Take him, then receivers in Rounds 3 and 4.
- **You opened WR-WR.** Take a back with each of your next two picks. Not "best available" — a back.
- **A Tier-1 name falls two rounds.** Take him. Price is the whole argument.

ROSTER

TARGET ROSTER · 16 ROUNDS · 12 TEAMS · 1 QB

POSITION	COUNT	FROM
Running back	5	One anchor in Rounds 1–2. One from the Round 4–6 leverage tier. Three after Round 7.
Wide receiver	6	Two by Round 4. Two from the Rounds 5–8 inheritors. Two darts after Round 13.
Tight end	2	One in Round 2, or two after Round 11. Nothing in between.
Quarterback	1–2	Round 5 at the earliest, and only for Jackson or Daniels. Otherwise two from Tier 4.
D · K	1 · 1	Your last two picks.

DRAFT MORNING

- **Re-pull ADP.** These numbers are from late July.
- **Check designations, not rankings** — Mahomes, Nabers, Charbonnet, Rice.
- **Print tiers, not ranks.**
- **Confirm your scoring.** Half-PPR moves receiving backs a full round.

09 Mock drafts

Full 16-round mocks built off the boards. Name and position only.

1st pick				1.01	
R1	Jahmyr Gibbs	RB	R9	Josh Downs	WR
R2	Chase Brown	RB	R10	Jadarian Price	RB
R3	DeVonta Smith	WR	R11	Ryan Flournoy	WR
R4	Emeka Egbuka	WR	R12	Kenneth Gainwell	RB
R5	Bhayshul Tuten	RB	R13	Gunnar Helm	TE
R6	Luther Burden III	WR	R14	Tyler Shough	QB
R7	Colston Loveland	TE	R15	Rams D/ST	DST
R8	Bo Nix	QB	R16	Kicker	K
Middle pick				1.06	
R1	Amon-Ra St. Brown	WR	R9	Josh Downs	WR
R2	James Cook	RB	R10	Kenneth Gainwell	RB
R3	George Pickens	WR	R11	Gunnar Helm	TE
R4	De'Von Achane	RB	R12	Jadarian Price	RB
R5	Rashee Rice	WR	R13	Chig Okonkwo	TE
R6	Cam Skattebo	RB	R14	Tyler Shough	QB
R7	Luther Burden III	WR	R15	Broncos D/ST	DST
R8	Bo Nix	QB	R16	Kicker	K
Last pick				1.12	
R1	Bijan Robinson	RB	R9	Josh Downs	WR
R2	CeeDee Lamb	WR	R10	Bhayshul Tuten	RB
R3	Jonathan Taylor	RB	R11	Bo Nix	QB
R4	Nico Collins	WR	R12	Ryan Flournoy	WR
R5	Bucky Irving	RB	R13	Gunnar Helm	TE
R6	Malik Nabers	WR	R14	Tyler Shough	QB
R7	TreVeyon Henderson	RB	R15	Ravens D/ST	DST
R8	Colston Loveland	TE	R16	Kicker	K

10 Sources

Forty-six links, and what this page can't promise.

Consensus-leaning composites from established outlets, not any single board. Where credible shops disagreed — tight end especially — the disagreement is shown. ADP and injury status are perishable: this is the picture as of **25 July 2026**.

[NFL.com — WR rankings and tiers](#)

[NFL.com — QB rankings and tiers](#)

[NFL.com — TE rankings and tiers](#)

[NFL.com — Top seven RB values](#)

[NFL.com — Top seven WR values](#)

[NFL.com — Free agency tracker](#)

[NFL.com — Mike Evans to San Francisco](#)

[NFL.com — Mahomes targeting Week 1](#)

[ESPN — Super Bowl LX](#)

[ESPN — A.J. Brown trade](#)

[ESPN — Mike Evans leaves Tampa Bay](#)

[ESPN — Sleepers, breakouts, busts](#)

[CBS Sports — QB top-12](#)

[CBS Sports — Rookie WR projections](#)

[CBS Sports — Rookie RB rankings](#)

[CBS Sports — TE tiers](#)

[PFF — Tiered tight ends](#)

[PFF — Late-round sleepers](#)

[Footballguys — 10 deep sleepers](#)

[FantasyPros — Early-round strategy](#)

[FantasyPros — Zero RB](#)

[FantasyPros — Late-round QB](#)

[FantasyPros — Rookie RBs to target](#)

[FantasyPros — Second-year outlooks](#)

[RotoWire — Breakout rookies and sophomores](#)

[RotoWire — WR tiers](#)

[NBC Sports — D.J. Moore fallout](#)

[NBC Sports — Waddle fallout](#)

[NBC Sports — Charbonnet on PUP](#)

[NBC Sports — Post-draft rookie RBs](#)

[Yahoo — Boone's RB rankings](#)

[Yahoo — Boone's WR rankings](#)

[Yahoo — Injuries that matter](#)

[Yahoo — Camp roundup](#)

[RotoBaller — Mahomes outlook](#)

[RotoBaller — Rashee Rice outlook](#)

[SI — Sleepers, all 32 teams](#)

[SI — Deep sleepers by position](#)

[Draft Sharks — Sleepers](#)

[PFF — Team defense rankings and tiers](#)

[SportsLine — DST tiers](#)

[FantasyPros — Best defenses](#)

[FantasyPros — Streaming defenses](#)

[Fantasy Life — DST streamers to target](#)

[ESPN — D/ST draft rankings](#)

[FantasyPros — Consensus ADP](#)